

hoc, debauched and degenerate.

Despite the fact that the Puritans were only a minority to begin with and were entirely engulfed by later infusions of non-Puritan stock into the American melting pot, the influence of the Puritan heritage on American thought and behavior can be noted even to this day.

Then, there is the Colonial and Revolutionary tradition which so many alleged authorities have quite incorrectly defined as having demanded a complete break with all that was European, including the "decadent" cultures of England and the Continent.

The founding fathers desired no such thing. They sought political independence from England and wished to eliminate monarchy and titled aristocracy from the American scheme. But most leading figures of the American Revolution hoped to preserve the cultural traditions of the Old World and to transplant the highly developed art and culture of England and Europe to the New World.

Benjamin Franklin, George Washington, John Adams—

to mention only three—were all men of culture. Anyone who has ever visited Thomas Jefferson's home in Monticello must have been impressed by the flawless taste reflected in the architecture and furnishings of the house built by this man who read the classics in Greek and Latin.

But then, one need look no further than the architecture of the nation's capital to find refutation of the theory that the founders of the United States desired to discard foreign artistic and cultural influences. The Capitol Building and the White House, both designed soon after the Revolutionary War ended, are excellent examples. The Capitol Building is strongly reminiscent of St. Peter's

173

Basilica in Rome. There is a startling resemblance between the main facade of the White House and that of the Duke of Leinster's home in Dublin, on which architect James Hoban based his designs for the Executive Mansion.